own soil. Even if the Chinese outflank us and cut our rear, we must not be perturbed. As we are dependent on the air supply, we must hold on to the good defences of Se-la.'

While Hoshiar Singh was not willing to even contemplate a withdrawal, GOC 4 Division was falling prey to the incessant negative talk that seemed to grip staff officers right up the chain of command. Even at the time, it was well known that some senior officers including the BGS, Brigadier K. K. Singh, and the Corps HQ were extremely unhappy with Se-la's selection over Bomdila as the line of defence. In fact, the GSO-1 in 4 Division HQ, Lieutenant Colonel Manohar Singh, had been freely voicing his opinion in favour of a retreat, openly saying the Chinese were invincible, so much so that Pathania at one stage thought of asking for his replacement. This antagonism towards what was seen as 'Palit's plan' seems to have coloured the interpretation of what was said on both sides when Pathania spoke to K. K. Singh.

Despite having failed to get firm orders from Thapar or Sen in the absence of Kaul to withdraw 4 Division, Pathania again spoke to Hoshiar Singh after which the brigade commander called a conference in his bunker at 6.30 p.m. The minutes of the meeting, attended by Lieutenant Colonel Budhwar (OC Field Regiment), Major Bakshi (OC Field Company Engineers), Major Jaidev Singh Datta (BM) and Major A. O. Alexander (DAA&QMG) state:

> The General Officer Commanding 4 Infantry Division had a telephone conversation for about half an hour with the Brigade Commander. According to the General, the situation in the rear was NOT satisfactory. The Chinese have managed to establish a roadblock KM 6 between Bomdila and Dirang Dzong—strength seems to be about one battalion. The General enquired about the situation at Se-la. Commander 62 Infantry Brigade informed him that covering troops of 4 Garhwal Rifles at Nuranang and two companies of 4 Sikh LI had accomplished their job admirably and have been ordered back to Se-la. The Brigade can hold on to Se-la for about a week; if air supply is not affected the Brigade will be quite happy to stay on at Se-la.
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> The General could not guarantee full air supply to the Se-la Brigade, thus wanted the entire Brigade to fall back on Bomdila rather than lose the whole Brigade at Se-la. If the enemy cuts off Se-la, the Division had no reserves to open up the road to Se-la. The General was keen that 62 Infantry Brigade should withdraw on the night of November 17-18 itself, join up with 65 Infantry Brigade and Divisional Headquarters and then bash on to Bomdila. However, Commander 62 Infantry Brigade thought withdrawal on the night of November 17-18 would spread panic and wanted, under these circumstances, to withdraw instead on the night of November 18-19; the General agreed to this proposal. The General also authorized Commander 62 Infantry Brigade to demolish Bridge 1 on the road near Dirang Dzong and Bridge 2 south of Senge. Two companies of 13 Dogras were sent to Divisional Headquarters on the night of November 17-18.